

Part I — The Setup

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The act opens with a transformation of the set. The bare chair-circle of Act One is gone; what is revealed is built on two levels. The upper platform is the rehearsal stage — where the family's drama will be staged. The lower floor is everything outside the performance: where the actors watch, where the Six wait between scenes, where the technical apparatus of the house lives. The Step-Daughter erupts from the lower floor onto the upper platform with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair dragged behind her. She has just lost an argument we did not witness. The Son and Mother emerge after her on the lower floor, circling each other in silence and accusation. The Father follows last.

The stage darkens around her. The shower-light falls on her only — a tight overhead column, narrow enough for one performer and not two. She kneels with the Child-bundle in her arms and the Boy-chair leaning beside her, and she speaks, alone, to her two silent siblings. The pianist plays Satie's *Gymnopédie No. 1* underneath. The monologue is live, in person, in the column of light: tender to the Child-bundle as if it were a real four-year-old; turning, mid-speech, to seize the coat hanging on the chair and take the revolver from its pocket. The audience does not need a screen for any of it. The speech is to the Child-bundle and the chair; the actor's care for both does the work.

Then the apparatus of the theatre reasserts itself — all of it now on the upper platform. The Property Man carries the table up. The Machinist places the pegs. The folding screen is wheeled into position. The white parlour is fitted up on the upper level, built around the family's pain like furniture, because that is what theatres do with grief. The Prompter takes shorthand from his box on the lower floor. The Manager paces between levels as he assigns names to the Characters. The Father falters at the sound of his own name.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

The stage call-bells ring to warn the company that the play is about to begin again.

The Step-Daughter comes out of the **Manager's** office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair behind her. As she comes out of the office, she cries: —

She seizes the stage in the same breath she refuses it — stepping forward with the children while claiming she wants no part of the mess.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Nonsense! nonsense! Do it yourselves! I'm not going to mix myself up in this mess. *[Turning to the Child-bundle in her arms and coming quickly onto the stage.]* Come on, Rosetta, let's run! *[She drags the Boy-chair to a spot a little behind her and leaves it there, leaning.]*

The stage darkens around her. The shower — a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, slow and child-haunted, beneath what follows. She kneels with the Child-bundle held against her chest, the Boy-chair leaning a short pace away. She speaks the next monologue live, alone in the column of light.

Beneath the lullaby, a forensic inventory: she already knows the revolver is in that pocket, and her tenderness is a farewell she cannot say plainly.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[bends over the Child-bundle and takes the cloth between her hands as if it were a small face].* My little darling! You're frightened, aren't you? You don't know where we are. *[Pretending to reply to a question of the Child.]* What is the stage? It's a place, baby, where people play at being serious — and we've got to act a comedy now, dead serious. You're in it too. A garden — a fountain — look — just suppose, little one, it's here, right in the middle. It's all pretence, my pet. All make-believe here. Better to imagine it, because if they fix it up for you, it'll only be painted cardboard — for the rockery, the water, the plants. Ah, but I think a baby like this would sooner have a make-believe fountain than a real one. What a joke it'll be for the others! But for you, alas, not such a joke. You who are real, baby dear, and really play by a real fountain, big and green and beautiful, with bamboos around and a whole lot of little ducks swimming. — *[She turns, sets the Child-bundle down carefully beside her, and reaches for the coat hanging on the Boy-chair. She takes the coat by the sleeve as if she were taking the Boy by the arm.]* What have you got there? *[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver. She holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket.]* Ah! Where did you get this? Idiot! If I'd been in your place, instead of killing myself I'd have shot one of those two — or both. Father and son.

The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds on her for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair. The Boy and the Child are silent objects again.

Cheerful efficiency is how he erases her — 'it's all fixed up' quietly abolishes the question of what she wants.

THE FATHER. Come on, come on dear! Come here for a minute! We've arranged everything. It's all fixed up.

Excitement has replaced neutrality; he is no longer a referee but a co-conspirator, pulling her toward the office he once presided over.

THE MANAGER *[also excited].* If you please, young lady, there are one or two points to settle still. Will you come along?

Her sarcasm lands and then dissolves — she follows anyway, trapped inside the story she would most like to destroy.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[following him towards the office].* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything. *[The Father, Manager and Step-Daughter go back into the office again (off) for a moment. At the same time, The Son followed by The Mother, comes out.]*

Contempt is the only wall he has left; 'I can't even get away' admits the wall is not working.

THE SON *[looking at the three entering office].* Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away. *[The Mother attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the Child-bundle into her lap and draws the Boy-chair close beside her. She casts a glance again at the Son, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

She genuinely believes that suffering in silence should excuse others from watching — the Son's refusal to look away devastates her.

THE MOTHER. Isn't my punishment the worst of all? *[Then seeing from the Son's manner that he will not bother himself about her.]* My God. Why are you so cruel? Isn't it enough for one person to carry all this? Must you make others see it too?

The Mother rises. She takes one step toward the Son, the Child-bundle still in her arms.

Two syllables, no more — she reaches for him knowing the hand will not be taken.

THE MOTHER *[barely].* My son —

The Son turns away before the word is finished. She stops where she is; the unfinished word stays in the air between them. After a moment she sits again, and holds the Child-bundle a little lower, as though it had grown heavier in her arms.

| *By dragging the parents' private life into the open, he dismantles the very idealization that had protected him from his own shame.*

THE SON [*half to himself, meaning the **Mother** to hear — eyes on the floor*]. And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. [*Pauses.*] He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about my case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

| *Pencil down: the story has crossed into territory that a professional record cannot ethically follow.*

PLAYER 3 [*very quietly, the pencil gone still in their hand*]. *Mon Dieu.* I've stopped writing it down. I don't want a record of this one.

*The **Mother** hides her face in her hands. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back of the stage the **Actors** and **Stage Manager** return, followed by the **Property Man**, and the **Prompter**. At the same moment, **The Manager** comes out of his office, accompanied by the **Father** and the **Step-Daughter**.*

| *A director's voice reasserting itself over material that has stopped behaving like material.*

THE MANAGER [*trying to take the rehearsal back, his director's voice returning*]. Come on, come on, ladies and gentlemen! Right — you there, machinist!

| *Even in a walk-on reply, Leading Man habit survives — vanity finds a way to color two words.*

PLAYER 1 [*two words; somehow still managing to deliver them as a Leading Man*]. Yes, sir.

| *A domestic space reduced to a lighting problem and a door: the Manager's shorthand for the room where the Step-Daughter was sold.*

THE MANAGER. Fix up the white parlor with the floral decorations. Two wings and a drop with a door will do. Hurry up!

*The **Machinist** runs off at once to prepare the scene, and arranges it while **The Manager** talks with the **Stage Manager**, the **Property Man**, and the **Prompter** on matters of detail.*

| *The sofa question is not casual — the right furniture is a piece of evidence, and he does not yet know that.*

THE MANAGER [*to **Property Man***]. Just have a look, and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

| *Institutional inertia delivered with flat certainty: the theatre stocks the sofa it has always had, indifferent to what any particular scene actually requires.*

PLAYER 2 [*the Property Man's voice, flat and certain*]. There's the green one. It is the sofa we have. It has always been the sofa we have.

| *Yellow with flowers is not a preference but a forensic fact — the exact sofa is the only one that holds her memory of that afternoon.*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No no! Green won't do. It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

| *The theatre simply does not carry the specific object of real shame — a quiet admission of the medium's limits.*

PLAYER 2. There isn't one like that.

| *'It doesn't matter' is the production's original sin: convenience chosen over fidelity, and she will not forget it.*

THE MANAGER. It doesn't matter. Use the one we've got.

| *Wrong props will make her truth look invented; 'most important' is a fight to keep reality from being swallowed by approximation.*

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Doesn't matter? It's most important!

Silencing her to demand the shop window shows he understands the scene's geography even while refusing to understand her.

THE MANAGER. We're only trying it now. Please don't interfere. *[To **Property Man**.]* See if we've got a shop window — long and narrowish.

Named with a survivor's precision — the mahogany table and pale blue envelope are relics she has never once stopped seeing.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

Gilt for mahogany: another small substitution that cheapens the moral economy of the room without the Manager registering the difference.

PLAYER 2 *[to **Manager**]*. There's that little gilt one.

Breezy acceptance where careful attention was owed — he is dressing a set rather than reconstructing what happened.

THE MANAGER. That'll do fine.

One word, one small vanity: even in his own disgrace, he wants a mirror close by.

THE FATHER. A mirror.

Without the screen the scene cannot be staged as she lived it — half-hidden, half-visible is not a staging preference but the truth of the memory.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to *manage*?

'Any amount of them' inadvertently mocks the scene's singularity: the theatre is generously stocked in screens for shame.

PLAYER 2. That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

Asking about clothes pegs is the moment he grasps the room's function — and the moment he becomes a co-author of the exposure.

THE MANAGER *[to the **Step-Daughter**]*. We want some clothes pegs too, don't we?

She knows the wall, the screen, the exact placement — the knowledge of someone who memorized every object in a room they wanted to escape.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[she knows the geography of that room — knows where Madame Pace kept everything]*. Yes. Several. There were always several. On the wall by the screen.

Compensating for the wrong sofa with a surplus of smaller props — logistical overkill that cannot repair the larger failure of fidelity.

THE MANAGER. See how many we've got and bring them all.

Wordless efficiency: the theatre services the scene without pausing to ask what happened there.

PLAYER 2 *[a half-nod; she is already on her way]*. Right.

*The **Property Man** hurries off to obey his orders. While he is putting the things in their places, the **Manager** talks to the **Prompter** and then with the **Characters** and the **Actors**.*

Asking the Prompter for something 'out of the ordinary' quietly concedes that ordinary theatrical procedure has already been left behind.

THE MANAGER *[to **Prompter**]*. Take your seat. Look here: this is the outline of the scenes, act by act. *[Hands him some sheets of paper.]* And now I'm going to ask you to do something out of the ordinary.

The doubled question — 'shorthand? in shorthand?' — betrays surprise that a living performance will need a written record at all.

PLAYER 3 *[looking up from the book; an unusual request to receive at this hour]*. Take it down in shorthand? Sir — in shorthand?

Pleasant surprise at a basic skill exposes how improvised the enterprise has become; he is solving problems he never anticipated because he never anticipated these Characters.

THE MANAGER *[pleasantly surprised]*. Exactly! Can you do shorthand?

'A little' hedges against an extraordinary assignment — he already senses this shorthand will record something that should not be lost.

PLAYER 3. Yes, a little.

Paper and stage hands mobilizing: the theatre's administrative apparatus gearing up to witness something it cannot fully contain.

THE MANAGER. Good! *[Turning to a Stage Hand.]* Go and get some paper from my office, plenty, as much as you can find. *[The Stage Hand goes off, and soon returns with a handful of paper which he gives to the Prompter.]*

Directing the actors to become audience inverts the normal hierarchy — the Characters have displaced the professionals from the center of the stage.

THE MANAGER *[to Prompter]*. You follow the scenes as we play them, and try and get the points down, at any rate the most important ones. *[Then addressing the Actors.]* Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here *[Pointing to the left.]* and listen attentively.

An unfinished objection is all she manages; the Leading Lady senses her role is being evacuated before she knows what will replace it.

PLAYER 2. But, excuse me, we...

'You won't have to improvise' is ironic reassurance — the Characters are about to force exactly the unscripted reality that trained actors fear most.

THE MANAGER *[guessing her thought]*. Don't worry! You won't have to improvise.

Vanity turning to acid: the applause joke is how the Leading Man wraps his demotion in theatrical gossip to save face.

PLAYER 1. What have we to do then — sit and applaud? I can do that. I've been doing that all season — at every other company's premiere in the canton, in fact.

'They're going to act now' treats the Characters' existence as a demonstration piece — a pedagogical exercise for his company rather than a collision with reality.

THE MANAGER. Nothing. For the moment you just watch and listen. Everybody will get his part written out afterwards. At present we're going to try the thing as best we can. They're going to act now.

Bewilderment at the word 'rehearsal' cuts to the philosophical core: a fixed Character does not rehearse its reality, it simply lives it.

THE FATHER *[as if fallen from the clouds into the confusion of the stage]*. We? What do you mean, if you please, by a rehearsal?

Clarifying that the rehearsal is for the Actors inadvertently concedes that the Characters need no preparation because they already are.

THE MANAGER. A rehearsal for them. *[Points to the Actors.]*

The unfinished sentence proves its own point: a Character does not argue for its existence — it simply is the argument, and the incomplete clause enacts that.

THE FATHER. But since we are the characters...

Pointing to the prompter's box to locate theatrical authority in text is precisely what these bookless Characters have come to destabilize.

THE MANAGER. All right: "characters" then, if you insist on calling yourselves such. But here, my dear sir, the characters don't act. Here the actors do the acting. The characters are there, in the "book" *[Pointing towards Prompter's box.]* — when there is a "book"!

The Actors' desire to 'be' the Characters is, for the Father, proof that Characters possess a reality the Actors can only approximate.

THE FATHER. I won't contradict you; but excuse me, the actors aren't the characters. They want to be, they pretend to be, don't they? Now if these gentlemen here are fortunate enough to have us alive before them...

Sarcastic 'grand' covers real fear: if Characters perform themselves, the theatre's mediating function — and his own authority — become redundant.

THE MANAGER. Oh this is grand! You want to come before the public yourselves then?

'As we are' is his entire manifesto in three words — unmediated, uninterpreted, unacted — and also the most dangerous thing you can put on a stage.

THE FATHER. As we are...

The irony backfires: 'magnificent spectacle' is exactly what the Characters offer and exactly what the theatre cannot reproduce — he has stated his own defeat.

THE MANAGER. I can assure you it would be a magnificent spectacle!

'Furniture with opinions' is wounded pride, but it accidentally names the Actors' structural role once the Characters arrive — decoration for a drama that has outgrown them.

PLAYER 1. What is the use of us here, then? Furniture with opinions?

Laughter covers genuine unease; 'they cast themselves' surrenders authorial control while pretending to exercise it.

THE MANAGER. You're not seriously going to pretend you can act? It makes me laugh! *[The Actors laugh.]* There, you see, they are laughing at the notion. But, by the way, I must cast the parts. That won't be difficult. They cast themselves. *[To the Second Lady Lead.]* You play the Mother. *[To the Father.]* We must find her a name.

Giving the real name is an act of fidelity that the theatre will immediately refuse — the gap between the real and the representable opens here.

THE FATHER. Amalia, sir.

Protocol, not malice: the theatre's need to sanitize lived identity into manageable fiction, dressed as a professional courtesy.

THE MANAGER. But that is the real name of your wife. We don't want to call her by her real name.

The moment representation enters, he hears his own words 'ring false' — a precise, devastating diagnosis of what theatre does to real experience.

THE FATHER. Why not, if it's her name?... Still, perhaps, if that lady must... *[Makes a slight motion of the hand to indicate the Second Lady Lead.]* I see this woman here *[Means the Mother.]* as Amalia. But do as you like. *[Gets more and more confused.]* I don't know what to say to you. Already I can hear my own words ring false...

Brisk efficiency papers over the Father's vertigo; assigning names and roles, he reclaims directorial ground by reducing persons to functions.

THE MANAGER. Don't you worry about it. It'll be our job to find the right tones. And as for her name, if you want her to be Amalia, Amalia she is. If you don't like it, we'll find another! For the moment though, we'll call the characters in this way: *[To Juvenile Lead.]* You are the Son. *[To the Leading Lady.]* You naturally are the Step-Daughter...

Her laugh is not at the woman but at the obscenity of the substitution — that body cannot contain what the Step-Daughter carries, and she knows it in an instant.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[a single hard laugh, head turning]*. What? What? I — that woman there?

Impatience, but also defensiveness: he chose the Leading Lady and cannot afford to have the choice mocked aloud.

THE MANAGER *[angry]*. What is there to laugh at?

'Reasonable lighting' lands beside 'respect' not as vanity but as a technical demand — she knows she will look wrong in this scene and is negotiating survival.

PLAYER 2 *[indignant]*. Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go.

Not contempt but something closer to pity: she is not laughing at the woman, but at the impossibility of the task assigned to her.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. No, no, excuse me... I'm not laughing at you...

Flattery dressed as honour: he uses the theatre's institutional prestige to shut down the Step-Daughter's instinctive refusal of her substitute.

THE MANAGER *[to Step-Daughter]*. You should feel honored to be played by...

Wounded vanity fires faster than thought — 'that woman' lands like a slap, and she retaliates before she can stop herself.

PLAYER 2 *[at once, contemptuously]*. "That woman there"...

Grief dressed as aesthetic objection: her self is not transferable, and no amount of resemblance can close that distance.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. But I wasn't speaking of *you*, you know. I was speaking of myself — whom I can't see in you at all. I don't know quite how to put it — but no, you really aren't anything like me.

Philosophy is his armour — he seizes the opening and pivots from personal wound to metaphysics the moment raw feeling threatens to break through.

THE FATHER. True. Here's the point. Look here, sir, our temperaments, our souls...

Crude pragmatism deflates the Father's intellectualising: the theatre has claimed the characters, and souls do not appear on the running-sheet.

THE MANAGER. Temperament, soul — to hell with all that! Do you suppose the spirit of the piece is in you? Nothing of the kind!

Not rhetorical innocence but wounded possessiveness — he cannot endure the thought that his interiority belongs to someone else to dispose of.

THE FATHER. What, haven't we our own temperaments, our own souls?

A power grab cloaked as craft: he subordinates their living pain to institutional process and redirects the credit to his own company.

THE MANAGER. Not at all. Your soul or whatever you like to call it takes shape here. The actors give body and form to it, voice and gesture. And my actors have given voice to material far more lofty than this little drama of yours — which may or may not hold up on the stage. But if it does, the merit of it, believe me, will be due to my actors.

Vulnerability weaponised — 'terrible suffering' is real and also strategic, deployed to reclaim moral ground from the Manager's dismissal.

THE FATHER. I don't dare contradict you, sir; but, believe me, it is a terrible suffering for us who are as we are, with these bodies of ours, these features to see...

His faith that surface can substitute for essence — make-up as cure-all — is the very delusion the play has come to destroy.

THE MANAGER [cutting him short and out of patience]. Good heavens! The make-up will remedy all that, man, the make-up...

His quietest and most precise argument: the body that carries shame cannot simply be painted over.

THE FATHER. Maybe. But the voice, the gestures...

The play's central violence stated baldly — an ontological eviction issued as a stage direction, neat and absolute.

THE MANAGER. Now, look here! On the stage, you as yourself, cannot exist. The actor here acts you, and that's an end to it!

He suddenly grasps why the Author abandoned them: to be staged is to be falsified, and that falsification is worse than non-existence.

THE FATHER. I understand. And now I think I see why our author who conceived us as we are, all alive, didn't want to put us on the stage after all. I haven't the least desire to offend your actors. Far from it! But when I think that I am to be acted by... I don't know by whom...

Chin lifted, bearing arranged — an actor performing dignity offstage, always auditioning, never not performing.

PLAYER 1 [on his dignity — chin lifted, the bearing arranged]. By me, if you've no objection.

The bow and 'honored' are a trap: elaborate courtesy sets up the devastating 'but' that will erase the compliment entirely.

THE FATHER [with a small bow toward Player 1]. Honored, I assure you, sir. Still, I must say that try as this gentleman may, with all his good will and wonderful art, to absorb me into himself...

Vanity cracks the instant irony is suspected; he cannot distinguish sincerity from condescension and the uncertainty undoes him.

PLAYER 1 [the dignity cracking]. Oh — come off it. "Wonderful art." He says it like he means it. Withdraw that, please.

However skilled the imitation, the actor can only produce his own version of the Father — the original stays permanently out of reach.

THE FATHER. The performance he will give, even doing his best with make-up to look like me...

Laughter as retreat: the Leading Man lets the audience share the joke rather than concede the Father's unanswerable point.

PLAYER 1. It will certainly be a bit difficult! *[The Actors laugh.]*

A pre-emptive bid for interpretive authority — he wants the final word on his own story before it is taken from him and handed to critics.

THE FATHER. Exactly! It will be difficult to act me as I really am. The effect will be more — apart from the make-up — how he supposes I am, how he senses me — if he senses me at all — and not how I, inside myself, feel myself to be. So it seems to me that anyone whose job it becomes to criticise us should take this into account...

He cannot answer the Father's argument, so he buries it under stage management, pivoting to logistics as a form of refusal.

THE MANAGER. Heavens! The man's starting to think about the critics now! Let them say what they like. It's up to us to put on the play if we can. *[Looking around.]* Come on! come on! Is the stage set? *[To the Actors and Characters.]* Stand back — stand back! Let me see, and don't let's lose any more time! *[To the Step-Daughter.]* Is it all right as it is now?

Not scenic criticism but a statement of identity: the real site of her humiliation cannot be reproduced, only approximated into insult.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Well, to tell the truth, I don't recognize the scene.

Condescension — 'you can't possibly suppose' — masks genuine limitation; theatre is always approximation, and he will not admit it.

THE MANAGER. My dear lady, you can't possibly suppose that we can construct that shop of Madame Pace piece by piece here? *[To the Father.]* You said a white room with flowered wall paper, didn't you?

Bare confirmation, all intellectual scaffolding stripped away — the room suddenly real and close in a single syllable.

THE FATHER. Yes.

Brisk furniture-moving reduces the site of the Step-Daughter's degradation to props on a checklist, obscene in its efficiency.

THE MANAGER. Well then. We've got the furniture right more or less. Bring that little table a bit further forward. *[The Stage Hands obey the order. To Property Man.]* You go and find an envelope, if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman. *[Indicates Father.]*

A mundane question that makes the absurdity plain: an instrument of shame is being requisitioned like a paperclip.

PLAYER 2. An ordinary envelope?

The one moment Father and Manager speak as one — both needing the same ordinary envelope to contain an extraordinary transaction.

THE MANAGER AND THE FATHER. Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

Crisp obedience: the machinery of theatre moves without moral pause, however freighted the object it has been sent to fetch.

PLAYER 2. At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

One woman simply swapped for another — the double correction lays bare the substitution at the heart of all theatrical representation.

THE MANAGER. Ready, everyone! First scene — the Young Lady. *[The Leading Lady comes forward.]* No, no, you must wait. I meant her *[Indicating the Step-Daughter.]* You just watch —

Compulsion, not performance pride: she needs to re-enact her degradation because only she can carry its full, unmediated weight.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[adding at once]*. How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

Professional reflex misreads existential desperation as a competitive slight — the Leading Lady hears rivalry where there is only grief.

PLAYER 2 *[offended]*. I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

His first real crack: he has been managing chaos all scene, and now even the cast list has a gap he cannot fill.

THE MANAGER *[with his hands to his head]*. Ladies and gentlemen, if you please! No more useless discussions! Scene I: the young lady with Madame Pace: Oh! *[Looks around as if lost.]* And this Madame Pace, where is she?

A quiet sentence that reopens the metaphysical problem just when the Manager believed he had closed it — Pace exists on different terms.

THE FATHER. She isn't with us, sir.

Exasperation at the limit of his craft: you cannot cast a character who arrives only on her own conditions.

THE MANAGER. Then what the devil's to be done?

He asserts that Pace, like all of them, has autonomous fictional existence — a claim that will be proved, disturbingly, within moments.

THE FATHER. But she is alive too.

A mundane question exposing how theatre thinks in locations; existence without a mark on the stage plan is simply invisible.

THE MANAGER. Yes, but where is she?

Both conjuring-trick and thesis: he believes the props of her trade can summon the character who needs them.

THE FATHER. One minute. Let me speak! *[Turning to the Actresses.]* If these ladies would be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

Half surprised, half laughing — the company's exact condition throughout: unsettled but still treating the uncanny as comedy.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3 *[half surprised, half laughing, in chorus]*.

A reasonable question that is completely beside the point; he has not yet grasped that the Father is performing a genuine summoning.

THE MANAGER. What are you going to do with the ladies' hats? *[The Actors laugh.]*

Mantles added to hats — the ritual extends, each item placed with almost priestly care, each one an invocation.

THE FATHER. Oh nothing. I just want to put them on these pegs for a moment. And one of the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

Grudging, bemused compliance: the company slowly cedes control without realising what it is surrendering.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3.

Individuals begin to separate from the chorus as unease grows — the group fractures where comedy stops working as a defence.

PLAYER 1 & PLAYER 2.

Courtesy kept scrupulously in place: politeness holds the actors inside a ritual they do not understand and have not consented to.

THE FATHER. To hang them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

Hanging their hats and cloaks, the actors become unwitting participants in a séance — the theatre company pressed into service as a medium.

PLAYER 1, PLAYER 2 & PLAYER 3 *[taking off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and going to hang them on the racks]*.

Two words name the logic of the summons: she is a creature of display, and she will come to where her merchandise is visible.

THE FATHER. Exactly; just like that, on show.

Institutional reason confronting something it cannot categorise — he needs a rational explanation before he can take another step.

THE MANAGER. May we know why?

Pirandello's thesis made literal: fiction is not written but called into being by conditions, and the Father has just proved it.

THE FATHER. I'll tell you. Who knows if, by arranging the stage for her, she doesn't come here herself, attracted by the very articles of her trade? *[Inviting the Actors to look towards the exit at back of stage.]* Look! Look!